



Department of English
College of Arts and Sciences
Box 32052
Boone, NC 28608-2052
(828)262-3098
Fax: (828)262-2133
english.appstate.edu

May 21, 2026

Dear Hiring Committee,

It is my genuine pleasure to recommend Lea Merritt for a position on your team. I had the opportunity to work with Lea in my Technical Writing and UX/UI course at Appalachian State University, and she distinguished herself as one of those students you find yourself thinking about long after the semester ends.

Lea is pursuing a degree in Computer Information Systems with a concentration in Cybersecurity, and what sets her apart is the sophistication with which she integrates technical knowledge with human-centered thinking. In a field that often treats those two things as separate, Lea understands they are inseparable. Her usability research project on the North Carolina DMV website demonstrated this clearly: she designed and conducted original user testing, identified meaningful accessibility barriers, and proposed design improvements grounded in real-world inclusivity principles. The work was rigorous, empathetic, and immediately applicable.

In the classroom, Lea communicated complex technical problems with clarity and precision, a skill that cannot be taught easily and one that will serve her well in any collaborative or client-facing role. She also brought something rarer: the ability to hold both analytical and interpersonal demands at once. Her background in high-pressure, metrics-driven environments has given her the kind of professional grounding many candidates her age simply don't have yet.

Her leadership record reinforces this profile. The AFJROTC Outstanding Flight Award and the U.S. Army Recruiting Command Award for academic excellence and leadership are not ceremonial distinctions; they reflect sustained performance under accountability. Her First Prize finish in the Living Magazine Essay Contest points to a student who can think and write with precision across contexts.

Lea's career interests sit at the productive intersection of UX research, cybersecurity, and human-centered systems design. She is the kind of candidate who will grow quickly in a role that rewards curiosity, adaptability, and clear thinking, and who will bring a user-first perspective to technical problems that others may approach too narrowly.

I recommend her without reservation.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "SRL", written in a cursive style.

Dr. Sarah Long
Professor, Rhetoric and Technical Writing
Department of English
Appalachian State University